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FREE WHITE PAPER | NOVEMBER 2026 | 12 MINUTE READ

AR8 bids are due by 9 December. Choose your route to market first.

Choose your route to market, then win it: CfD rounds, merchant, corporate PPAs and private wire, for energy developers in the UK and Europe

On a 60 MW solar project, every £1/MWh on the clearing price is worth about £58,000 a year. Missing the round by a year costs about £2.6m in today's money.

The working is on page 2. The four questions that find the anchor route are on page 6.

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Not legal, regulatory or investment advice. Dates checked 31 October 2026; dates after 19 November are indicative.

00 THE ANSWER FIRST

Pick the anchor route before 19 November. After that, the round sets your timetable.

For CEOs and commercial leads at energy developers. The AR8 budget notice lands on 19 November. Sealed bids are indicatively due 3 to 9 December.[12,13,14] Your decision: the anchor route for each project, and your lowest acceptable price.

WHAT £1/MWH IS WORTH

£58,000 a year

about £0.61m over a 20-year contract, in today's money

WHAT A ONE-YEAR SLIP COSTS

about £2.6m

in today's money, if the project waits for the next round

Example project: 60 MW solar, 11% capacity factor (assumption)	**57,816 MWh a year**
£1/MWh on the clearing price: 57,816 × £1	**£57,816 a year**
Over 20 years at a 7% discount rate (assumption): × 10.594	**about £0.61m**
Revenue at the AR7 solar price: 57,816 × £65.23[1]	**about £3.77m a year**
Value of 20 years of that revenue today: £3.77m × 10.594	**about £39.9m**
Most likely: one year later. £39.9m × (1 − 1/1.07)	**about £2.6m lost**
Downside: two years later. £39.9m × (1 − 1/1.07²)	**about £5.1m lost**

Worked example: 60 MW solar, 11% capacity factor, 20-year contract, 7% discount rate, AR7 solar clearing price of £65.23/MWh in 2024 prices. The capacity factor and discount rate are Ignis assumptions. Method on page 12.

THREE FINDINGS

1. **The route is a decision, not a deadline.** Rounds are bigger and more contested. AR7 awarded 14.7 GW across 201 projects. Germany's August onshore round drew twice the volume on offer.[1,4]
2. **Know how the round pays.** The UK CfD pays one clearing price per pot and year. Your floor price decides whether you win, not what you earn. In a pay-as-bid round, your bid is your income.[16,4]
3. **Hold a second route.** Spain's November 2022 auction offered 3,300 MW and awarded 45.5 MW. Projects there went to PPAs instead.[11]

DECIDE BEFORE 19 NOVEMBER 2026

For each project: the anchor route, a floor price on current evidence, and a signed bid or no-bid reason.

Yorik Tisseau, Founder, Ignis Leadership | November 2026 | 12 minute read | Inside: why now (p3), the four routes (p4 to p6), how to decide (p7 to p8), self-check (p10), the cost of waiting (p11), sources (p12)

01 WHY NOW

Rounds are fuller, rules are changing and buyers are pickier

So what: more routes, fuller rounds, stricter rules. Each route needs its own case. Your board will be held to these dates.

Date	What happens	Source
7 Aug 2026	AR8 application window closed	[12]
19 Nov 2026	AR8 budget notice and Notice of Auction	[13]
3 to 9 Dec 2026	AR8 sealed bids (indicative until 19 November)	[14]
15 to 17 Feb 2027	AR8 results (indicative)	[13,14]
17 Jul 2027	New EU direct price support for wind and solar must be two-way CfDs or equivalent	[8]

14.7 GW

Awarded across 201 projects in the UK's seventh CfD round, the largest to date.[1]

2.1 times

Germany's 1 August 2026 onshore wind round drew 5,250 MW of bids for 2,520 MW on offer.[4]

3 times

France's July 2026 onshore wind tender drew 2,378 MW for 800 MW; the average price fell by €9.5/MWh.[5,6]

The rules are moving

Across the EU, non-price criteria must now apply to at least 30% of each country's auctioned renewable volume, or 6 GW a year. The ability to deliver on time is among the tests.[7]

From 17 July 2027, new direct price support in the EU must take the form of two-way contracts for difference or an equivalent.[8] In the UK, CfDs for wind and solar run for 20 years from AR7, up from 15.[9]

Buyers are pickier

Disclosed European PPAs came to 13.1 GW across 247 deals in 2025, down from 15.3 GW in 2024. Spain stayed the largest market at 3.9 GW.[10]

> SHORT ANSWER
>
> Is a round still the safest anchor? Often, yes. But a fuller round means more projects lose, so the fallback route needs its own case before bids go in.



02 THE FOUR ROUTES IN PLAIN WORDS

Four ways to sell the power, four different cases to make

So what: each route has a different audience to convince. Know who it is before you build the case.

ROUTE 1

CfD round or state auction

A government round awards long-term price support. The UK runs CfD allocation rounds such as AR7 and AR8; France runs CRE tenders; Germany, the Netherlands and Spain run their own auctions.

You convince: the round's rules, with a sealed price and the evidence to qualify.

ROUTE 2

Merchant

The project sells at market prices, often with hedges, short-term deals or a trading partner. Common as the tail after a contract ends, and sometimes as the plan for part of the output.

You convince: your board and lenders that the price case holds.

ROUTE 3

Corporate or private PPA

A long-term contract with a buyer: a company, a utility or a trader. It can be physical, sleeved through a supplier, or virtual (financial). Terms, tenor and credit decide its value.

You convince: one buyer's energy, legal and credit teams.

ROUTE 4

Private wire

A direct cable from the project to a nearby user, such as an industrial site or a data centre, usually alongside a grid connection. It can avoid most network charges, but it needs its own consent, land rights and licence position.

You convince: one user, the landowners on the route and the planners.

Recent rounds cleared well below their caps

Round	Technology	Price	Source
UK AR7	Offshore wind, England and Wales	£91.20/MWh	[3]
UK AR7	Floating offshore wind	£216.49/MWh	[3]
UK AR7	Onshore wind	£72.24/MWh	[1]
UK AR7	Solar	£65.23/MWh	[1]
France, CRE	Onshore wind, weighted average	€77.08/MWh	[5]
Germany, EEG	Onshore wind, weighted average	4.79 ct/kWh	[4]

UK prices in 2024 money. AR8 caps: solar £75, onshore wind £92, offshore wind £113 per MWh, 2024 prices.[15] France: July 2026 onshore tender. Germany: 1 August 2026 onshore round.

02 HOW THE ROUTES COMPARE

No route wins on every count

So what: each route trades certainty for upside or control. Pick the trade your lenders accept.

HOW THE FOUR ROUTES USUALLY COMPARE

	CfD round	Merchant	Corporate PPA	Private wire
Price certainty	●●● Fixed strike price	●○○ Market price	●●○ Fixed or floored, per deal	●●○ Long contract, one buyer
Lender comfort	●●● Well understood	●○○ Needs hedges or more equity	●●○ Depends on buyer credit	●○○ Project on project risk
Upside you keep	●○○ Pays back above strike	●●● All of it	●●○ Shared, by structure	●●○ Shares network savings
Control of timing	●○○ Set by the round calendar	●●● Your own	●●○ Negotiated, can stall	●○○ Cable consent and land
Evidence to win	●●● Qualification and scoring	●●○ Lender price case	●●○ Buyer due diligence	●●● Consent, licence, metering
Onshore fit	●●● Main route in many markets	●●○ Often a later tail	●●● Strong where buyers exist	●●○ Only near large demand
Offshore fit	●●● Usual anchor	●○○ Rarely alone	●●○ Part of the mix	●○○ Rarely practical

Source: Ignis view, a qualitative framework rather than data.

Does the round pay my bid or the clearing price?

Short answer: in the UK, the clearing price. In Germany's onshore rounds, your bid.

The UK CfD is **pay-as-clear**: every successful project in a pot and delivery year gets the same clearing price.[16] Bidding lower raises your chance of winning, not your income, so the work that matters is an honest floor price.

Germany's onshore wind auctions are **pay-as-bid**: each winner gets its own bid.[4] There the bid price is the income, and every euro counts twice.

Which route should anchor the project?

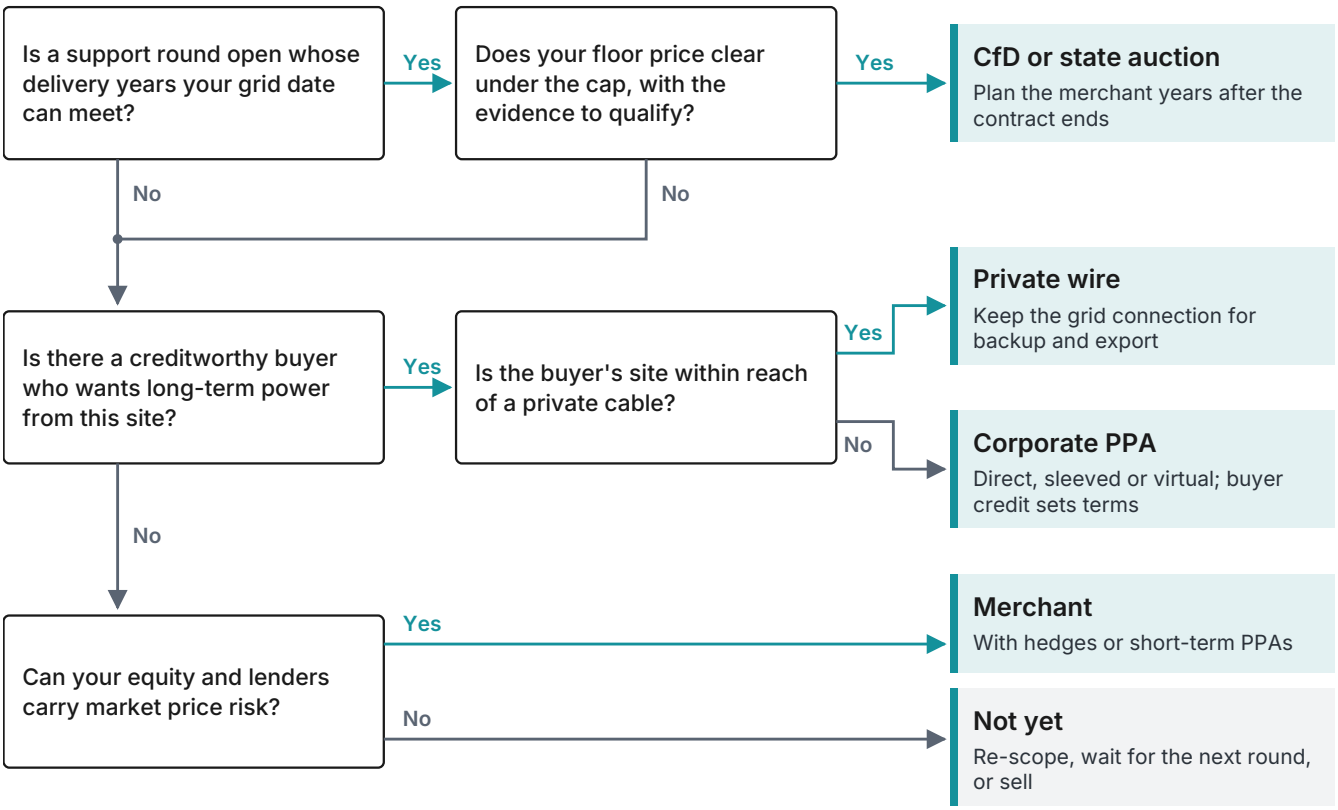
Short answer: the one that makes it financeable.

A CfD covers the contract years and leaves a merchant tail. A PPA can cover part of the output while the rest sells at market. The useful question is which route is the **anchor**.

02 CHOOSING THE ANCHOR ROUTE

Four questions find the anchor route

So what: four questions give each project one anchor route. Ask them yearly, and whenever a round, buyer or grid date changes.



Source: Ignis framework. Free to use with your team.

Offshore

Scale and capital cost usually make a state round the anchor. Corporate PPAs join the mix in some markets. The grid date and supply chain set the credible delivery year. With fewer, larger rounds, aim for a lower cost per bid, not more bids.

Onshore

All four routes are live. A strong corporate buyer or a nearby large user can beat the next round on timing, and a round can beat a thin PPA market on price certainty.

Many markets, the same questions

The names change: CfD allocation rounds in the UK, CRE tenders in France, EEG auctions in Germany, renewables auctions in Spain and the Netherlands. The questions do not: can the grid date meet the delivery year, does the floor price clear, who else would buy the power, and who can carry the price risk.

Where teams slip: answering the first question from the round calendar instead of the grid date, and the second from last year's capex.

03 HOW YOU DECIDE TODAY

Most value is lost between documents, not inside them

So what: fix the process before you buy a tool. Value leaks in the hand-offs.

1 The deadline picks the route

The next window decides where the project goes, not a comparison of routes.

Fix: a portfolio calendar and an anchor route per project, reviewed each quarter.
Cost: Wasted bid cost, and senior focus taken off the bids that matter.

2 Evidence rebuilt every time

Land, consent, grid, yield and cost evidence is gathered again for each round or buyer.

Fix: one evidence library per project, with an owner and a date on every item.
Cost: Hours lost, and stale inputs in front of buyers and lenders.

3 The floor price set late

The walk-away is agreed in the final week, on inputs nobody has rechecked.

Fix: set the floor at the bid or no-bid gate, on current capex, yield and grid evidence.
Cost: Bids priced below viability, or a contract won at a loss.

4 The same project, told differently

Capacity, dates and prices drift between the round, a PPA offer and the board paper.

Fix: cross-checks as a step no submission can skip.
Cost: Clarification questions, lost credibility and delivery-year risk.

5 Lessons never written down

Results, clearing prices and buyer feedback stay in inboxes.

Fix: a short debrief that goes back into the record after every round.
Cost: The same mistakes repeated across rounds.

Start with two

Pick the two loss points that cost you most, and find the reason for each. Fix those first. The rest can wait.

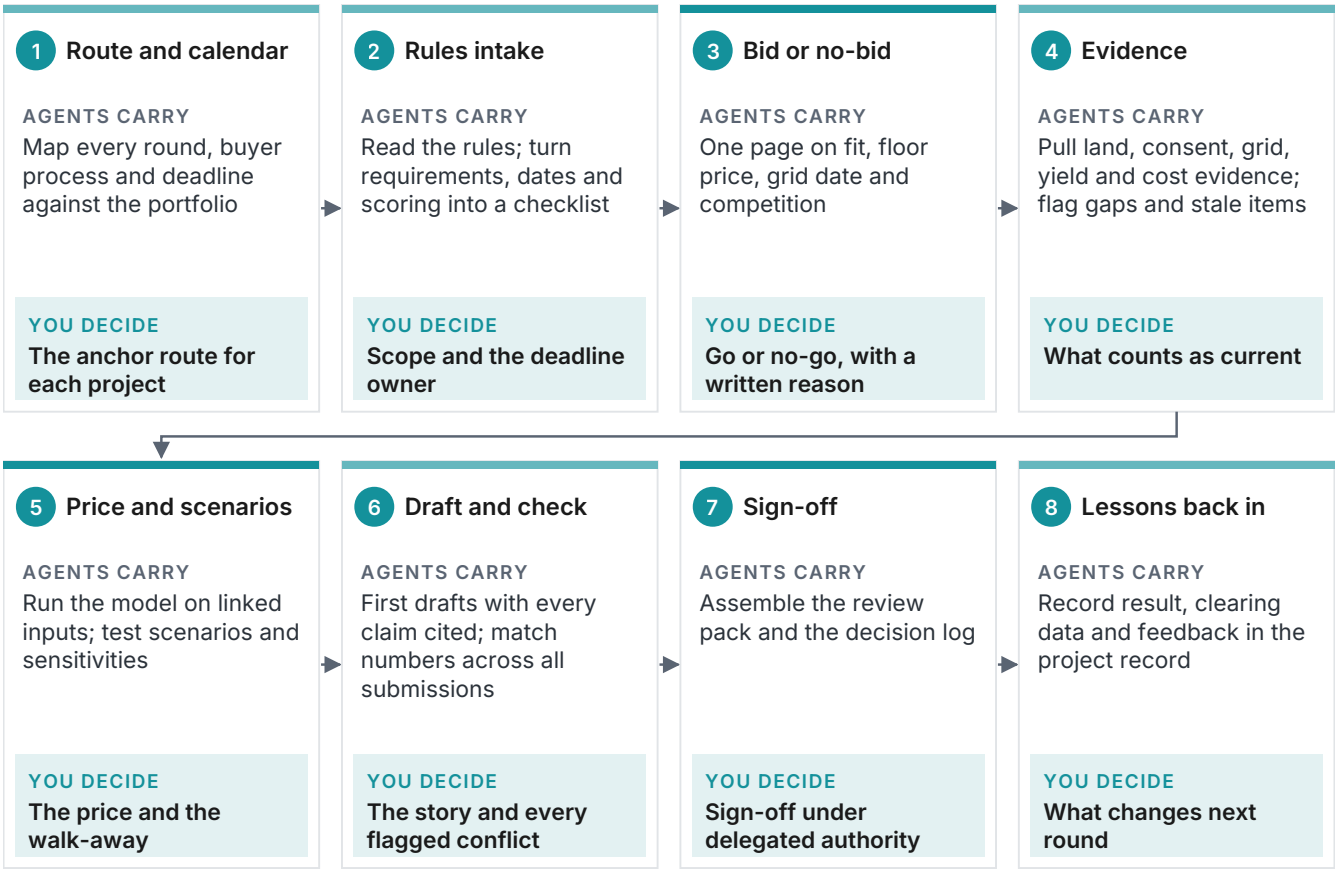
THE ORDER THAT WORKS

1 Process first	2 Data second	3 Agents third
What do you run today? Map how the route is chosen and how a bid is put together. Remove steps that add nothing. Simplify what is left.	**What does it run on?** One record per project: facts, evidence and assumptions, versioned and owned.	**Then add the agents,** on the redesigned process, with named people deciding at each gate.

03 WINNING THE ROUND

Eight steps take a project from route choice to a signed bid

So what: one sequence works for any route. Agents prepare. People decide at every step.



Source: Ignis framework.

Value a bid before you write it

> Bid value = chance of winning × margin if you win − cost of bidding − chance of an error × cost of that error

The last term is the one most teams leave out: a delivery year the grid date cannot meet, or a PPA offer that contradicts the round bid. Cross-checks cut it more cheaply than extra drafting hours.

Where agents help, and what stays human

- Agents read the rules, pull the evidence, run scenarios on linked inputs and match numbers across every submission.
- People keep the route, the price, the walk-away, partner terms and the signature.
- Every claim is traced to a source, and each round leaves a better record for the next.

03 WHAT A GOVERNED SET-UP LOOKS LIKE

Your record, your gates, your environment

So what: three things decide whether any set-up helps. One record per project. Named people at each gate. An audit trail.

People and gates
Route choice, bid or no-bid, price and walk-away, sign-off. Named people decide at each gate.

AI manager: plans the work, routes it to agents, checks it, brings each decision to a person

AGENTS

Rules reader Round rules and buyer terms	**Evidence** Land, consent, grid, yield	**Pricing** Scenarios on linked inputs
Drafting First drafts, all cited	**Cross-check** Numbers and dates match	**Market watch** Rounds, prices and buyers

CONNECTORS TO THE TOOLS YOU ALREADY USE

Financial model | Document store | Data room | Email, calendar | Bid portals

Your data and context: one record, owned by you, that improves with every project

- Project facts: capacity, dates, grid, consents
- Evidence library with owners and dates
- Past rounds: bids, results, debriefs
- Buyer and counterparty terms

Governance
Named gates
Audit trail
Access rules

Your environment

Source: Ignis framework, tool-agnostic.

1 Confidentiality you can prove

Agree where the models run, what they can read and who can see what, before any agent starts.

2 Roles, not redundancies

The aim is the same team doing more and better work. Each role is redesigned with the people in it.

3 An executive sponsor

A named executive owns the outcome and clears the blockers.

4 Questions to ask any vendor

Does it work from our documents, cite its sources, stop at our gates, and let us leave with our data?

04 SELF-CHECK

How ready is your team for AR8, and the round after it?

So what: your score shows where to start. Tick what is true today, not what is planned.

- ☐ Each project has a named anchor route, reviewed in the last six months
- ☐ We hold a 12-month calendar of every round and buyer process across the portfolio
- ☐ Every bid has a written bid or no-bid decision with a floor price
- ☐ Each project has one evidence library, with owners and dates
- ☐ Our pricing model reads the latest capex, yield and grid inputs
- ☐ Capacity, dates and prices are cross-checked across every live submission
- ☐ We know which rounds pay as clear and which pay as bid, and price accordingly
- ☐ Drafting and checking do not depend on one or two people
- ☐ Results, clearing prices and buyer feedback go back into the record
- ☐ We have mapped at least one bid process end to end and know its two biggest pain points

Score: 0 to 3, start with the route decision and a bid or no-bid gate. 4 to 7, fix the evidence library and the cross-checks, then add agents. 8 to 10, you are ready to take on more rounds and buyers with the same team.

Questions for your team on Monday

1. Which rounds and buyer deadlines fall in the next 90 days, and who owns each one?
2. What is our floor price for each, and when was it last tested?
3. Where does the same project appear with different numbers?
4. What did we learn from AR7, and where is it written down?



05 THE COST OF DOING NOTHING

Waiting a round is rarely free

So what: a one-year wait costs a 60 MW project about £2.6m. Decide it on purpose.

Case	What happens	Value lost today
Most likely	The project misses AR8 and bids the next round a year later, at a similar price	about £2.6m
Downside	The next round slips or the grid date moves, and contracted revenue starts two years later	about £5.1m
Bid too low	The floor is set on stale capex and the project wins at a price it cannot build to	[NOT IN RECORD]

60 MW solar example from page 2; Ignis calculation. The bid too low case depends on your capex and has no general figure.

Where you might disagree

A PPA may beat the round if your grid date misses the AR8 delivery years, or a creditworthy buyer is at the table. Waiting can be right if capex falls faster than prices. Decide it in writing before 19 November.

What to do this month

1. Run the four questions on page 6 for every project in or near AR8.
2. Refresh the floor price on current capex, yield and grid evidence.
3. Write the bid or no-bid reason and get it signed.
4. Check that capacity, dates and prices match across every live submission.

HOW IGNIS HELPS

Ignis advises energy developers on route to market and bid decisions. We work from your documents, with your team. We test the anchor route and floor price, map where the bid loses time, and recommend what to fix first. Your team decides and signs.

Talk it through with Yorik

One question you can answer in one reply: which project are you weighing between AR8 and a PPA this winter? Send its name and size to **ignisleadership.com/contact** and we will come back with the three questions we would ask first.

+ SOURCES AND METHOD

Sources

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16. DESNZ, CfD Allocation Round 7 Allocation Framework, 2025, rules 12.5, 12.6 and 13.1. assets.publishing.service.gov.uk (ar7-contract-allocation-framework.pdf)

Method and limits

Worked example. 60 MW × 8,760 hours × 11% capacity factor = 57,816 MWh a year. The 11% capacity factor and the 7% discount rate are Ignis assumptions for a UK solar project, not sourced figures. Present value uses a 20-year annuity factor at 7% (10.594), matching the 20-year CfD term from AR7.[9] Revenue uses the AR7 solar clearing price of £65.23/MWh in 2024 prices[1] as a proxy for AR8 and ignores indexation, merchant tail and costs. A one-year slip is valued as the 20-year stream discounted one year further; two years for the downside.

Dates. Every AR8 date after 19 November 2026 is indicative until NESO publishes the Notice of Auction. The official CfD timeline page could not be read directly; dates come from DESNZ's statement as reported in the trade press, and the sources agree.

Frameworks. The comparison matrix, the decision tree and the eight steps are Ignis views, free to use with your team. They are not data.

+ NEXT READS AND ABOUT IGNIS

TENDER TO CLOSE

Procurement without the pauses

Three clocks start when you win. How to keep supplier choice, contracts and the lender pack ahead of them.

ALL STAGES

Agentic transformation for energy developers

Where agents help from early stage development to financial close, and where they do not.

MONTHLY

Market Monitor

The dates, prices and rules that moved this month. ignisleadership.com/resources

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About Ignis

Ignis Leadership is an advisory practice for energy developers across the UK and Europe, onshore and offshore. We help teams win the right to develop and move projects to financial close, with fewer delays, fewer surprises and stronger terms. Expert-led, AI-assisted, on your data.

About Yorik Tisseau

Founder of Ignis Leadership. 17 years closing commercial deals on energy infrastructure.

Talk it through with Yorik:
ignisleadership.com/contact



Process first. Data second. Agents third.

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